

Exploring Neuromorphic Electronics

VO2 Memristors and Oscillatory Circuits

Peter Tallosy (K14WR1)

Budapest University of Technology and Economics

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Part 1: The Challenge and Motivation

Energy Crisis in Computation

AI training and inference consume megawatts of power due to the **von Neumann Bottleneck**. Moving data between CPU and memory costs $> 100\times$ more energy than the computation itself.

Neuromorphic Solution

The brain ($\approx 20W$) achieves efficiency by collocating memory and processing. Memristor crossbar arrays (right) replicate this, enabling **hardware-level single-step matrix-vector multiplication** [3]. This analog approach performs complex operations instantly via physics (Ohm's/Kirchhoff's laws).

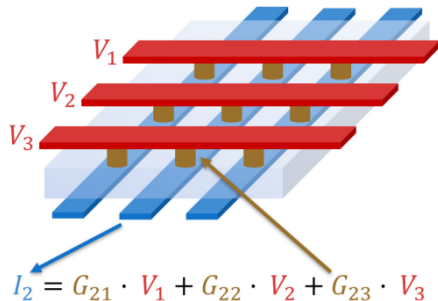


Figure 1: Memristor Crossbar Array

- **Theory:** Vanadium Dioxide (VO₂) Physics
- **Methods:** Measurement Setup and Objectives
- **Results:**
 - ▶ Voltage-Induced Switching (I-V)
 - ▶ Thermal Phase Transition (R-T)
 - ▶ Relaxation Dynamics (Oscillatory Behavior)
- **Conclusion:** Impact and Future Outlook

Theory: Vanadium Dioxide (VO₂)

Insulator-Metal Transition (IMT)

VO₂ is the premier material for artificial neurons. At room temperature, it acts as an insulator. However, above $\approx 68^\circ\text{C}$ (or when triggered by Joule heating), it physically transforms into a highly conductive metal.

Hysteresis and Memory

Crucially, the return path to the insulating state differs from the heating path. This **thermal hysteresis** provides the necessary "memory" effect, characterizing the device as a **Volatile Memristor**. Unlike non-volatile crossbars (synapses), these devices naturally generate spikes, mimicking biological neuron firing [4].

Switching Ratio

$$R_{ins}/R_{met} > 1000$$

Volatile Memristor

Measurement Session Roadmap

Our characterization session focused on four specific experimental tasks:

1. Circuit Validation

Verification of the measurement setup and safety limits using series resistor topology to prevent device burnout.

2. $I(V)$ Curve Characterization

Voltage sweeping to identify non-linear switching thresholds (Set/Reset voltages) and current-voltage hysteresis.

3. Temperature-Dependent Resistance

Direct observation of the physical phase transition by controlling the sample temperature externally.

4. Relaxation Dynamics

Time-domain analysis of the switching speed to evaluate feasibility for oscillatory circuits

Experimental Setup

Circuit Topology

We utilized a series circuit configuration:

$$V_{source} \rightarrow R_{series} \rightarrow VO2.$$

The protection resistor $R_{series} \approx 2.17k\Omega$ is critical. It prevents thermal runaway and destruction when the device switches to its low-resistance state.

Instrumentation

Current-voltage generation and sensing were handled by an **NI myDAQ** unit. A custom C# application was used to automate the parameter sweeps and data logging.

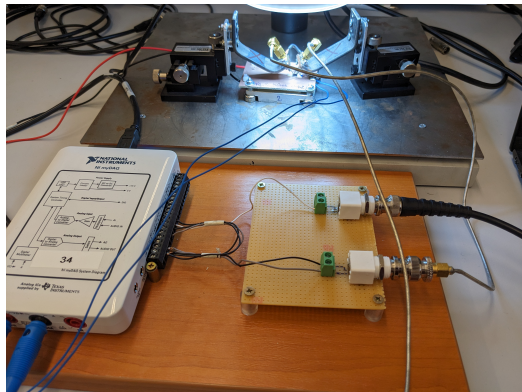


Figure 2: Measurement Setup with Probes

Result: Voltage-Induced Switching (Task 2)

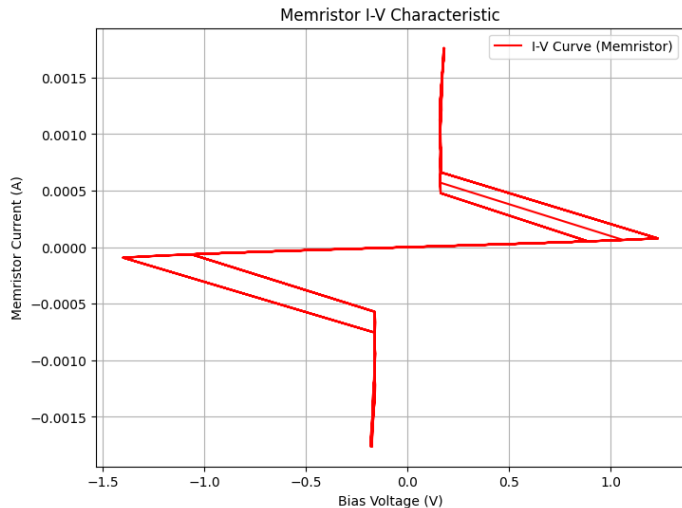
Threshold Switching

The experimental data reveals a clear hysteresis loop:

Set Transition: At $\approx 2.5V$, Joule heating triggers the IMT, causing a sharp current jump.

Reset Transition: As bias drops, the device cools and recovers high resistance at a lower voltage.

Volatility: The device always returns to the Off state at 0V, confirming volatile behavior.



Result: Time-Dependent Behavior

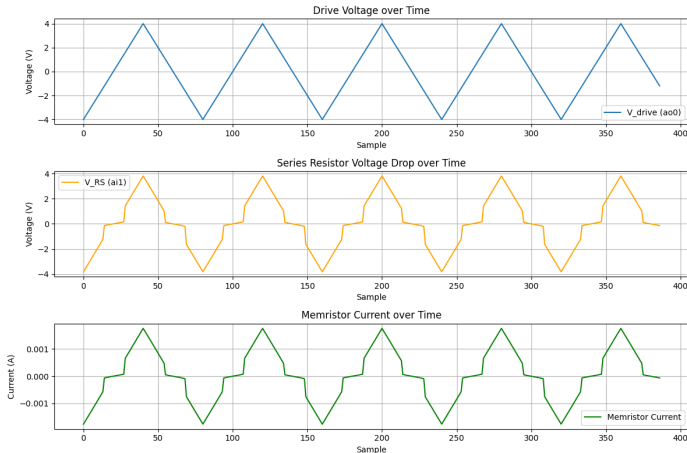


Figure 4: Time-dependent measurements during the $I(V)$ sweep: (top) drive voltage, (middle) series resistor voltage drop, (bottom) calculated memristor current.

Result: Thermal Phase Transition (Task 3)

Task 3: Temperature-dependent resistance

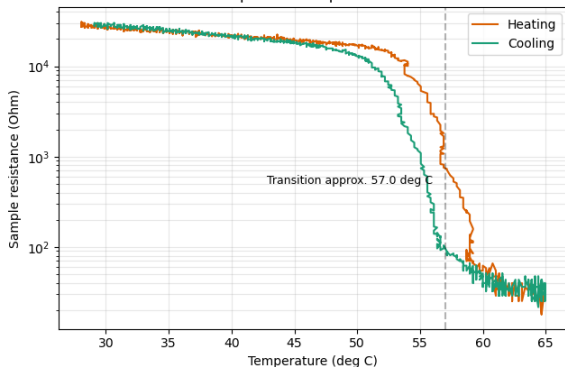


Figure 5: Resistance vs. Temperature

Physical Verification

To verify the switching mechanism, we heated the sample externally:

Sharp Transition: Near 57°C , resistance drops by orders of magnitude.

This confirms that the switching observed in the I-V curves is indeed driven by the Insulator-Metal Transition phase change, rather than purely electronic breakdown effects.

Result: Activation Energy Analysis

Arrhenius Analysis

By plotting $\ln(R)$ against $1/T$, we analyzed the conduction mechanism in the insulating state.

Semiconductor Behavior

The linear region indicates standard thermally activated transport ($R \propto e^{E_a/k_B T}$).

The results are consistent with standard semiconductor physics for VO₂ (typically $E_a \approx 0.3 - 0.5\text{eV}$), confirming the semiconducting nature of the Off state.

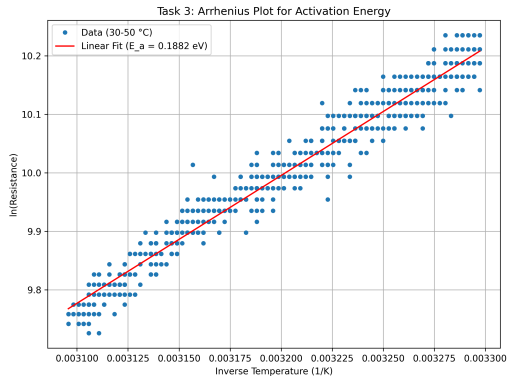


Figure 6: Arrhenius Fit of Resistance Data

Result: Relaxation Dynamics (Task 4)

Oscillator Attempt

We aimed to construct a Pearson-Anson relaxation oscillator (Neuristor) by biasing the device in its negative differential resistance region using a capacitor.

Observations vs. Challenges

We successfully triggered a single switching event, observing the characteristic current spike (shown right).

However, sustaining a stable oscillation train proved difficult. The device exhibited instability and degradation after repeated high-speed cycling. This highlights a key challenge in the field: ensuring device endurance for continuous neuromorphic operation.

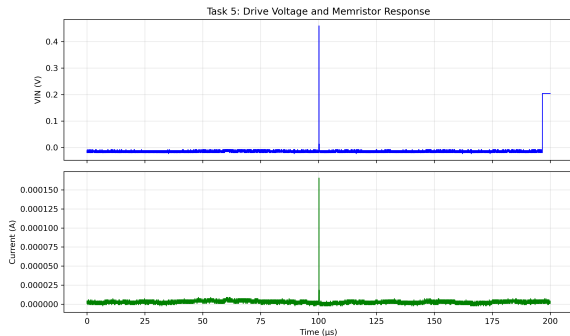


Figure 7: Transient Response to Pulse

From Lab to State of the Art: Ising Machines

Connecting Our Measurements to Frontier Research

Our single-device oscillator (Right: Task 4 result) represents the fundamental building block. While maintaining stability for one device was challenging, recent breakthroughs have scaled this concept massively.

The VO2 Ising Machine

Maher et al. (2024) recently demonstrated a system of **coupled VO2 oscillators** integrated on a CMOS platform [5].

- By coupling many oscillators (like the one we measured), they created an **Ising Machine Solver**.
- This analog computer naturally solves NP-hard optimization problems (e.g., Graph Coloring) by letting the coupled oscillators settle into a minimum energy state (synchronization).

Stochasticity and Neural Dynamics

In Task 3, we confirmed the thermal origin of the transition. Interestingly, the intrinsic noise and variability we observed are not just "errors"—they are features.

Stochastic Neurons

Yi et al. (2018) showed that the intrinsic stochasticity in VO2 memristors closely mimics the noise found in biological ion channels [6].

- This "noise" allows artificial neural networks to escape local minima during learning.
- Our verification of the switching physics confirms that these devices are not just digital switches, but biologically plausible, dynamical systems suitable for next-gen probabilistic computing.

Conclusion

Summary

We successfully characterized the VO₂ memristor, confirming its potential as a physical building block for neuromorphic hardware.

Key Findings:

- **Robust Switching:** Demonstrated a volatile On/Off ratio > 1000 .
- **Physical Verification:** Confirmed the thermal origin (IMT) and activation energy.

Outlook

While the switching physics is sound, improving device durability is the critical next step. Solving this will enable large-scale *Oscillatory Neural Networks* capable of solving complex NP-hard problems using coupled physics [5].

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References

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- [2] Y. Huang et al., “Memristor-based hardware accelerators for artificial intelligence”, *Nature Reviews Electrical Engineering*, 1, 286 (2024).
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